

The Lau Family Lineage

From the Tin Fields of Larut to Penang and Ipoh

Author

Ho Siew Khui 何小駒 (Hé Xiǎojū)

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Abstract

This study presents a reconstruction of a single documented line of descent within the Lau family lineage, tracing the family from the mining settlements of Larut to later generations established in Penang and Ipoh. Combining oral testimony, field investigation and documentary research, it seeks to preserve a family history situated within the broader history of Chinese settlement and enterprise in nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Malaya.

The narrative begins with Low Sam (劉三 / 刘三 Liú Sān), an early Chinese mining figure associated with the Larut tin fields during the period of the Larut conflicts. It then follows the transition of the family through Low Foo (劉富 / 刘富 Liú Fù), a Penang businessman, property owner and mining entrepreneur associated with Chulia Street and mining activities in Perak and Selangor, before tracing the later movement of the family to Ipoh under Lau Yau Weng (劉有榮 / 刘有荣 Liú Yǒuróng). The study also records later wartime experiences during the Japanese occupation and the continuation of the family lineage into the present generation.

Newly examined contemporaneous colonial records from the Colonial Office correspondence series (CO 273), accessed through Gale Primary Sources and Arkib Negara Malaysia, provide additional documentary evidence relating to Low Sam's activities during the Larut disturbances of 1872. These records materially extend the documented historical presence of Lew Ah Sam beyond the period traditionally emphasised in existing secondary accounts.

Newly identified Supreme Court proceedings reported in the *Pinang Gazette and Straits Chronicle* (26 February 1897) further strengthen the documented lineage by identifying Low Foo as administrator of the estate of his father, Low Ah Sam. This contemporaneous legal report provides direct documentary evidence confirming the father-son relationship previously preserved principally through family oral tradition and related documentary sources.

The work does not attempt a comprehensive reconstruction of all collateral branches of the Lau family. Rather, it focuses on a single documented line for which oral testimony, field observation and surviving documentary evidence could be meaningfully correlated.

As with many Chinese family histories in Malaya, surviving records remain uneven and incomplete. Personal papers, probate materials and cemetery records have often been lost, damaged or never formally preserved. This study therefore combines archival research, oral history and field investigation to reconstruct a family lineage situated within the broader history of Chinese settlement, migration and enterprise in nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Malaya.

The Lau Family Lineage

From the Tin Fields of Larut to Penang and Ipoh

1. Low Sam (劉三/刘三 Liú Sān)

(also rendered as Lau Sam / Law Ah Sam / Lew Ah Sam / Lew Sam in historical sources)

Early Chinese mining pioneer in Larut

The earliest known ancestor in this lineage is Low Sam (劉三 / 刘三 Liú Sān), a Chinese mining figure active during the formative years of the tin industry in Perak in the mid-nineteenth century.

Historical records do not preserve his name in a single standardised form. Contemporary sources variously refer to him as “Lew Sam”, “Lau Sam”, “Law Ah Sam” and “Lew Ah Sam”, reflecting the non-standardised Romanisation practices common in nineteenth-century Malaya, where Chinese names were rendered differently according to dialect, pronunciation and the recorder’s interpretation.¹ The prefix “Ah” (阿 ā) represents a familiar form of address rather than a distinct personal name.

Taken together, the convergence of name, role, location and historical period suggests that these references most likely relate to the same individual.

During this period, the rich tin deposits of Larut attracted large numbers of Chinese miners and entrepreneurs, whose operations were organised through powerful kongsi networks controlling labour, finance and security within the mining districts, as described in both contemporary accounts and later historical studies of Chinese secret societies in Malaya.²

Later historical studies further associate Low Sam with the early expansion of the Larut mines under Long Jaafar. One account states that Long Jaafar brought Chinese labourers from Penang through agents including Low Sam and Chung Keng Kwee, reflecting the organised labour and recruitment networks supporting the development of the Larut mining industry.³

Low Sam’s activities took place within the broader expansion of Chinese mining in Larut under the patronage of Malay chiefs including Long Jaafar and later Ngah Ibrahim.⁴

¹ Russell Jones, “Chinese Names: Notes on the Use of Surnames and Personal Names by the Chinese in Malaya,” *Journal of the Malayan Branch of the Royal Asiatic Society* 32, no. 2 (1959): 1–14.

² C. N. Parkinson, *British Intervention in Malaya 1867–1877* (Kuala Lumpur: University of Malaya Press, 1960);

M. L. Wynne, *Triad and Tabut: A Survey of Secret Societies in Malaya* (Singapore: Government Printing Office, 1941).

³ Noor Syamimi Mohamad Nazri and Mohd Shazwan Mokhtar, “Konflik Kongsi Gelap Cina di Perak, 1861–1874,” *Jurnal Wacana Sarjana* 8, no. 2 (2024): 3, referring to the recruitment of Chinese labourers from Penang through agents including Low Sam and Chung Keng Kwee.

⁴ Parkinson, *British Intervention in Malaya*, 1960.

During the Larut conflicts of the 1860s and early 1870s, Low Sam appears in multiple historical accounts as a recognised leader within the Chinese mining community.⁵ In one account, he is described as head of the Chung Shan Hakka group in Larut — a term used in historical sources corresponding to the Heung San (Xiangshan) district grouping within the Hai San organisation.⁶

The Hai San organisation was composed of several native-place groups drawn from districts in Guangdong, including Heung San, Hui Chew (Huizhou) and Cheng Seng (Zengcheng), reflecting the broader district-based structure of Chinese secret societies in nineteenth-century Malaya.⁷ During this period, Low Sam was approached in connection with efforts to maintain order, including a request to seek assistance from the Malay authorities, suggesting that he held a position of authority recognised by both Chinese mining groups and local Malay rulers.⁸

The early phase of the conflict is often described in secondary sources as having arisen from disputes among Chinese groups, sometimes linked to gambling or festival tensions. However, contemporary records do not clearly define Low Sam's precise role in initiating or mediating these disputes and his involvement is best understood within the broader leadership structure of the mining community during this period.

Beyond the conflicts, Low Sam appears to have been associated with the wider mining network dominated by Chung Keng Quee, later Kapitan China of Perak and one of the most influential Chinese figures in nineteenth-century Malaya.

Family accounts indicate that Low Sam originated from Panyu County (番禺县 Pānyú Xiàn) in Guangzhou, Guangdong Province, a recollection preserved by Yip Yuen Thoo (叶润桃 Yè Rùntáo), who related that her father-in-law Lau Hoi Leong (刘海量 Liú Hǎiliàng) had spoken of these origins.

Chan Sow Lin (陈秀连 Chén Xiù Lián), a later prominent figure in Malayan industry, is also recorded as originating from Panyu County,⁹ the same region associated with Low Sam. Shared native-place ties often formed the basis of trust and recruitment within nineteenth-century Chinese mining networks in Malaya.¹⁰

⁵ C.N. Parkinson, *British Intervention in Malaya 1867–1877* (1960);

Khoo Kay Kim, “Taiping (Larut): The Early History of a Mining Settlement,” *Journal of the Malaysian Branch of the Royal Asiatic Society* 64, no. 1 (1991), pp. 1–32.

⁶ Parkinson, *British Intervention in Malaya 1867–1877* (1960); W.L. Blythe, *The Impact of Chinese Secret Societies in Malaya* (1969). Parkinson refers to Low Sam (Lew Ah Sam) as associated with the “Chung Shan Hakka”, while Blythe documents the district-based organisation of the Hai San. The term “Zhongshan” only came into use after the district was renamed in 1925 in honour of Sun Yat-sen, and is therefore anachronistic when applied to nineteenth-century sources.

⁷ W.L. Blythe, *The Impact of Chinese Secret Societies in Malaya* (1969); C.N. Parkinson, *British Intervention in Malaya 1867–1877* (1960). Both works describe the organisation of Chinese secret societies in Malaya along native-place (district) lines.

⁸ Parkinson, *British Intervention in Malaya*, 1960.

⁹ Eugene Khoo, “Chan Sow Lin 陈秀连 (Chén Xiùlián),” *Overseas Chinese in the British Empire* (blog), 25 December 2011, accessed 12 April 2026.

¹⁰ Yen Ching-hwang, *A Social History of the Chinese in Singapore and Malaya, 1800–1911* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1986); Yen Ching-hwang, *The Chinese in Southeast Asia and Beyond: Socioeconomic and Political Dimensions* (Hackensack, NJ: World Scientific, 2008).

Chan Sow Lin is described in later secondary accounts, as having worked under Low Sam in the Larut mining industry during the late 1860s. These accounts further state that Low Sam later entrusted him with supervisory responsibilities over mining operations in Larut.¹¹ The precise nature of this working relationship remains unclear.

Within the Lau family, Low Sam is remembered as the early patriarch from whom the Penang branch of the family descends. This long-preserved family tradition is now independently corroborated by a contemporaneous report of Supreme Court proceedings published in the *Pinang Gazette and Straits Chronicle* on 26 February 1897. Reporting proceedings before Mr Justice Law, the newspaper identified "Low Foo as Administrator of the Estate of his father, Low Ah Sam deceased...", providing direct documentary evidence that Low Foo was the son of Low Sam. Together with the family's oral history, this legal record establishes the documented transition from Low Sam to the next generation represented by Low Foo. Details of Low Foo's early life remain limited, as is common for many early Chinese settler families in the Straits Settlements where personal records were seldom preserved.

Family accounts indicate that Low Sam had two wives, one of whom was remembered in oral testimony as being of Thai origin. Details concerning the other wife are no longer clearly preserved in family memory.

Field investigation at Mount Erskine Cemetery, Penang, identified two female graves within the Lau family burial cluster, located in close proximity and appearing as a paired burial that appears consistent with family accounts relating to the wives of Low Sam based on spatial association and the estimated period, with one considered a possible candidate for the mother of Low Foo (刘富 Liú Fù), later identified in family accounts as the son of Low Sam.

Earlier accounts of Low Sam generally become sparse following the Second Larut War of 1865, creating the impression that he had largely disappeared from the historical record thereafter. Previously overlooked contemporaneous colonial records from October 1872 housed within the Colonial Office correspondence series (CO 273) at The National Archives, Kew, United Kingdom, accessed through Gale Primary Sources and Arkib Negara Malaysia, demonstrate that Low Sam remained actively involved in the Larut disturbances several years later during the period immediately preceding the Third Larut War. These records include witness depositions, police intelligence reports, telegrams, and administrative correspondence referring directly to "Low Sam" alongside Chung Ah Quee and other Chinese leaders associated with the conflict.¹²

Particularly significant are witness statements recorded before Captain Tristram Charles Speedy in October 1872 describing the movement of armed men, firearms, and supply boats between Penang and Larut, including testimony that Low Sam and Chung Ah Quee were

¹¹ Eugene Khoo, "Chan Sow Lin 陈秀连 (Chén Xiùlián)," *Overseas Chinese in the British Empire* (blog), 25 December 2011, accessed 12 April 2026; see also Yen Ching-hwang, *The Chinese in Southeast Asia and Beyond: Socioeconomic and Political Dimensions* (Hackensack, NJ: World Scientific, 2008).

¹² British Colonial Office, "Correspondence, Original – Secretary of State Despatches," October 1872, CO 273/61, The National Archives (Kew, United Kingdom), reproduced in Gale Primary Sources: *Colonial Office Files for the Straits Settlements*, accessed via Arkib Negara Malaysia digital collections.

involved in the mobilisation efforts connected to the disturbances.¹³ The discovery of these contemporaneous references materially extends the documented historical presence of Low Sam beyond the period traditionally emphasised in existing secondary accounts.

After the Larut conflicts subsided, Low Sam is understood to have remained an influential figure within the Chinese mining community. The later life and final resting place of Low Sam are not clearly recorded in available historical sources, although one possible later archival reference to 'Lew Ah Sam' appears in Selangor records dated 1895.¹⁴

Family memory also preserves a possible indication of Low Sam's burial location. Yip Yuen Thoo, wife of Lau Yook Loon (刘玉麟 Liú Yùlín), recalled that approximately fifty years ago she accompanied her father-in-law, Lau Hoi Leong, to Mount Erskine Cemetery in Penang during the Qing Ming period to pay respects at what was identified to her as the tomb of Low Sam.

She further remembered that the site formed part of a substantial Lau family burial compound, within which the grave of Lau Yau Tuck (刘有德 Liú Yǒudé) and other family members were also present at that time. This recollection of a substantial burial compound is consistent with present site inspections identifying a clustered arrangement of Lau family graves at Mount Erskine, including a closely paired burial of two female graves within the same vicinity, suggesting continuity between the remembered and surviving burial landscape.

This recollection represents a rare first-hand family testimony linking Low Sam to Mount Erskine. In the absence of documentary evidence, this recollection provides an important oral record preserved among later descendants, suggesting that Low Sam may have been buried in Penang rather than having returned to China or relocated elsewhere.

These recollections preserve a family memory linking Low Sam to the Lau family burial ground at Mount Erskine in Penang.

2. Low Foo (劉富/刘富 Liú Fù)

Penang businessman and property owner

Low Foo, the son of Low Sam,¹⁵ represents the next generation of Chinese entrepreneurs who emerged after the first generation of Larut mining pioneers. Unlike his father, who was connected to the mining frontier in Perak, Low Foo was born in Penang, a fact confirmed by his descendants. His birth in Penang reflects the gradual transition of early Chinese mining families into the commercial centres of the Straits Settlements.

¹³ British Colonial Office, CO 273/61, witness depositions and intelligence correspondence dated 16–22 October 1872 referring to Low Sam, Chung Ah Quee, armed Chinese groups, transport of firearms by boat between Penang and Larut, and reports received by Captain T. C. Speedy during the Larut disturbances.

¹⁴ Arkib Negara Malaysia records dated 19 November 1895 refer to "Lew Ah Sam" in connection with disputed mining lease claims involving Lots 19, Sections I and II, Semeniyih. The record may represent a later reference to the Lew Ah Sam associated with the Larut mining community. Arkib Negara Malaysia (ANM), Identifier No. 1957/0059284W.

¹⁵ The filial relationship between Low Sam and Low Foo is directly confirmed by a report of Supreme Court proceedings published in the *Pinang Gazette and Straits Chronicle* (Penang), 26 February 1897, p. 2, which identifies "Low Foo as Administrator of the Estate of his father, Low Ah Sam deceased...". This contemporaneous legal report independently corroborates the family's long-preserved oral tradition.

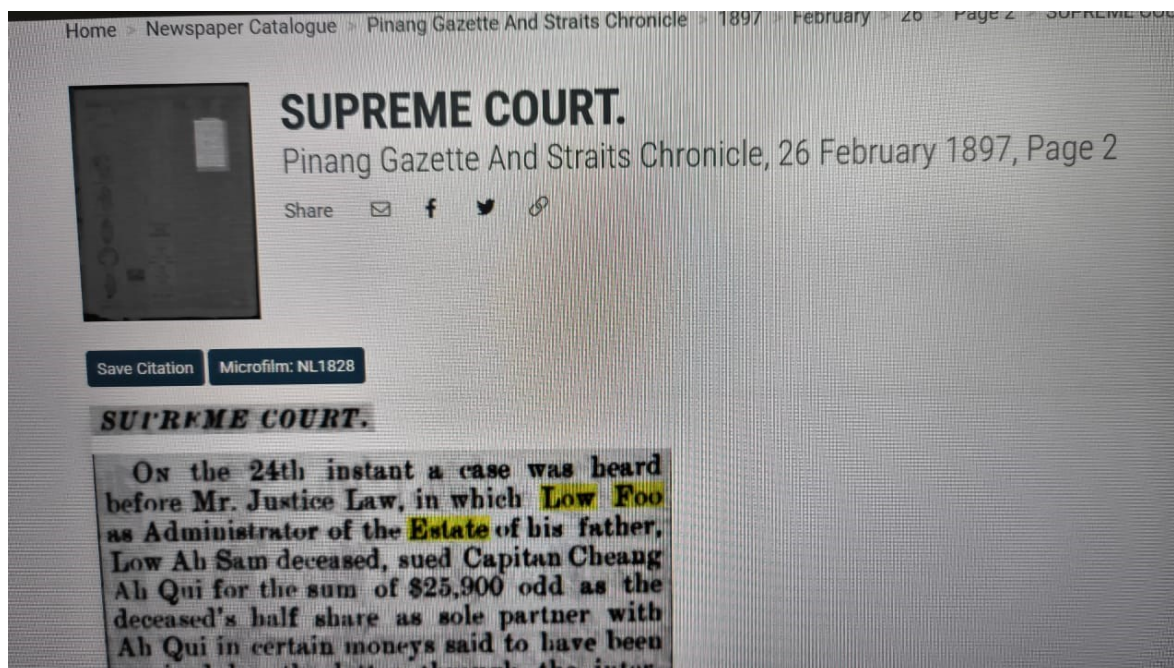


Figure 1. Report of Supreme Court proceedings published in the *Pinang Gazette and Straits Chronicle*, 26 February 1897. The report identifies "Low Foo as Administrator of the Estate of his father, Low Ah Sam deceased...", providing contemporaneous legal evidence confirming the father-son relationship between Low Sam and Low Foo.

Low Foo became a prominent businessman in Penang and is associated in family accounts with a large residence located at:

Nos. 381–383 Chulia Street
George Town, Penang

At the time, Chulia Street formed part of George Town's main commercial thoroughfares, associated with merchants, traders and lodging houses serving travellers arriving by sea.¹⁶ Within this historic urban fabric, properties often functioned as both places of residence and centres of enterprise, reflecting a pattern in which commercial and domestic life were closely intertwined.¹⁷

The property at Nos. 381–383 Chulia Street appears to have been designed as a substantial residence rather than a simple merchant townhouse. Its scale and layout, comprising multiple buildings, courtyards and ancillary structures, point to a large extended household. These features suggest a compound suited to both residence and associated functions within a single integrated space. Following Low Foo's death, the residence was later adapted and eventually became known as the Nam Wah Hotel.

A 1956 archival record held by Arkib Negara Malaysia further indicates that No. 381 Chulia Street was then associated with an organisation identified as "Thun Si Wung Yeong Thong,"

¹⁶ Khoo Salma Nasution, *Streets of George Town, Penang* (Penang: Areca Books, 2007).

¹⁷ UNESCO, World Heritage Centre, *Melaka and George Town, Historic Cities of the Straits of Malacca: Nomination Dossier* (2008).

suggesting that the property continued to function as an active commercial or institutional premises during the postwar period prior to its later identification as Nam Wah Hotel.¹⁸



Figure 2. Nam Wah Hotel, formerly the residence of Low Foo at Nos. 381–383 Chulia Street, George Town, Penang. Photograph by Kiyoshi Fujita (2008), reproduced for historical reference.



Figure 3. Residence associated with Low Foo at Nos. 381–383 Chulia Street, George Town, Penang (left and right views). The building presently houses a Middle Eastern restaurant. Photographs by Arnold Loh (2018).

¹⁸Arkib Negara Malaysia (ANM), archival record referring to “Thun Si Wung Yeong Thong” associated with No. 381 Chulia Street, Penang, dated 1956.



Figure 4. Low Foo Chye Hang (Low Foo Lane), shown in October 2018 (left) and April 2026 (right). The later photograph confirms the continued physical configuration of the lane, supporting its identification as the residential area associated with Low Foo's extended household. Photographs by Arnold Loh (2018, 2026).

Family recollections preserved within the Lau family indicate that Low Foo had multiple wives, remembered among surviving family accounts as numbering nine, with separate residences associated with the extended household compound behind the main residence at Nos. 381–383 Chulia Street. Probate and estate records document ownership of multiple adjacent properties along Chulia Street, including Nos. 375A and 375D, consistent with the existence of a substantial multi-household family compound.¹⁹

Following Low Foo's death, the family of Lau Yau Weng (刘有荣 Liú Yǒuróng), his eldest son, relocated to Ipoh with his mother, the widow of Low Foo and principal wife of the household, respectfully referred to within the family as 'Tai Thai' (大太 Dà tài), the matriarch. In Cantonese usage, the term refers to the principal or first wife. Her personal name is no longer clearly preserved in surviving family memory or documentary records. The Penang property remained under the Lau family's ownership.

A site visit conducted by the author in 2018 to the property at Nos. 381–383 Chulia Street showed that the structure extends significantly beyond the depth of a typical Penang shophouse, incorporating multiple internal courtyards. This configuration supports its use as a high-status residential compound rather than a standard commercial unit. Its scale and complexity are uncommon among urban dwellings of the period in George Town, which were generally limited to narrower, single-block shophouse forms. Taken together, these features are consistent with Low Foo's standing as a prominent and prosperous figure in the local community.

Further documentary linkage to the Penang household appears in the 1919 birth certificate of Lau Hoi Leong, son of Lau Yau Weng. The certificate records the child's birth at 381 Chulia Street, Penang, providing contemporaneous civil evidence associating this branch of the family with the Chulia Street residence linked to the wider Low Foo household network.

Further insight into the architectural features of the property was provided through direct communication with its present owner, Loke Gim Tay. The patterned floor tiles appear

¹⁹Affidavit of assets filed in the estate of Lau Yau Weng (c.1975), recording ownership of Nos. 375A and 375D Chulia Street; see also *Lau Yau Weng and Lau Yau Chi v Bank of Malaya Ltd* [1933] 1 MLJ 250, which describes Lin Pui Yew as "the surviving executrix and representative of the estate of Low Foo deceased."

consistent with Victorian-era encaustic-style tiles arranged in tessellated patterns, a form of decorative flooring widely used in Britain and across the British Empire during the nineteenth century. Such tiles were commonly manufactured and exported for use in both public buildings and private residences.

He also suggested that certain decorative elements on the pillars resemble stylised claws associated with the qilin (麒麟 *Qílín*), a motif in Chinese tradition often linked with auspiciousness and status.



Figure 5. Decorative pillar detail featuring motifs associated with the *qilin* (麒麟 *Qílín*) within the former residence at Nos. 381–383 Chulia Street.

The ornamental relief patterns observed on the pillar include stylised forms interpreted by the present owner as resembling elements associated with the *qilin* (麒麟 *Qílín*), a creature in Chinese tradition symbolising auspiciousness, dignity and status. Such decorative features reflect the incorporation of culturally significant motifs within the architectural design. Photograph by the author.



Figure 6. Interior architectural features of the former residence at Nos. 381–383 Chulia Street, George Town, Penang. The photographs show preserved elements including the original doorway design, internal proportions and high ceilings characteristic of Straits Settlements architecture. These features remain consistent with late nineteenth- to early twentieth-century residential design. Photographs by the author.

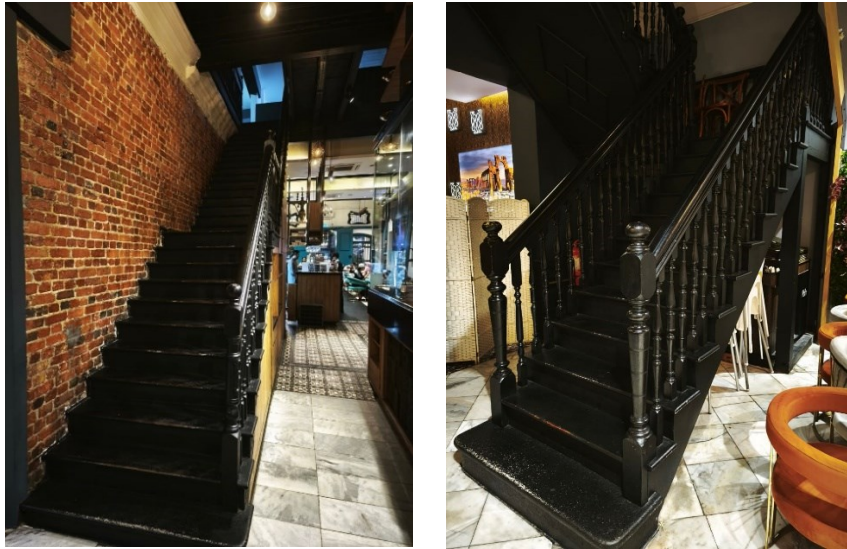


Figure 7. Internal staircase structures within the former residence at Nos. 381–383 Chulia Street. The wooden staircases, preserved within the structure, provide evidence of the building’s original internal circulation between floors. Their construction and placement are consistent with multi-level residential layouts associated with large extended households in the Straits Settlements period. Photographs by the author.

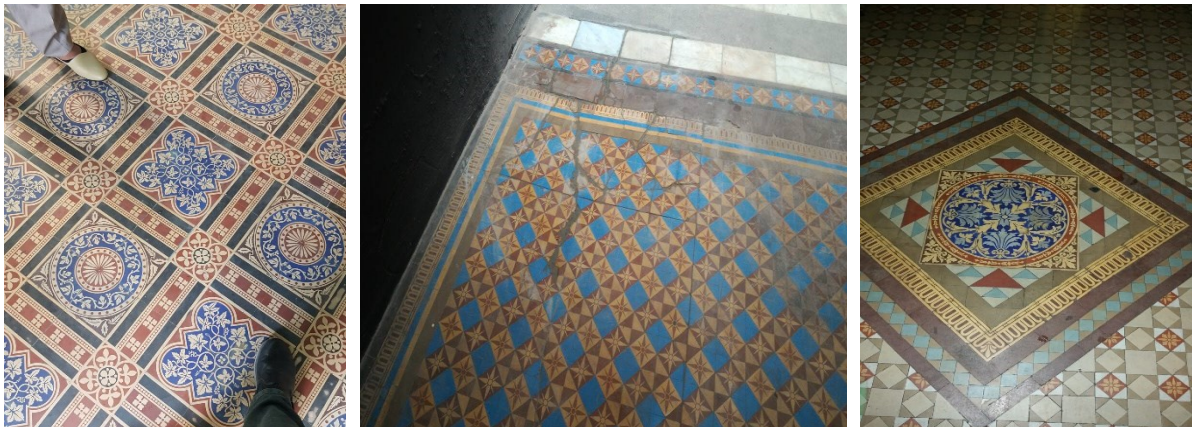


Figure 8. Decorative floor tiles within the former residence of Low Foo at Nos. 381–383 Chulia Street, George Town, Penang. The patterned tiles, featuring geometric and floral motifs arranged in both repeating fields and centralised panels, are consistent with decorative flooring found in late nineteenth to early twentieth century Straits Settlements residences. Observations on the materials and layout are based on the current condition of the building, with input from the present owner, Loke Gim Tay. Photographs courtesy of Loke Gim Tay.

Taken together, these architectural features, including the patterned floor tiles, reflect the circulation of imported building materials within colonial port cities such as Penang. This interpretation is further supported by informal consultation conducted by the author with heritage specialist Khoo Salma Nasution, who noted that such tessellated tiles were widely used in the United Kingdom and exported across the British Empire, rather than being confined to any single institutional source. Further informal input, relayed through Khoo Salma Nasution from Dr Gwynn Jenkins, a specialist in George Town’s built heritage and conservation, suggests that the tiles are consistent with products of British manufacturers such as Minton or Maw & Co., both known for producing encaustic and tessellated tiles for

widespread use across the Empire. Such materials contributed to the layered architectural character described by Khoo Salma Nasution in *Streets of George Town, Penang*.²⁰

The mansion at Nos. 381–383 Chulia Street is situated within what is now the George Town UNESCO World Heritage Site, with Chulia Street forming part of the protected historic urban fabric. Such buildings form part of a broader architectural landscape shaped by successive generations of trading communities, reflecting the historical role of Penang as a cosmopolitan entrepôt.²¹

The building is presently owned by Loke Gim Tay, a Penang-born entrepreneur and heritage property collector, as confirmed through direct communication. He is known for his involvement in the preservation of historically significant buildings in the state. The property remains in active use, reflecting its continued historical and architectural significance.

Low Foo's standing in the local community is further reflected in his contributions beyond his private enterprises. A commemorative fountain bearing his name records his donation of land for the General Hospital in Ipoh, providing material evidence of his role in supporting public infrastructure. The fountain originally stood within the grounds of the old Ipoh General Hospital and was subsequently relocated to the present Raja Permaisuri Bainun Hospital when the new hospital complex was built.



Figure 9. Low Foo Commemorative Fountain, dated 1900, within the compound of Hospital Raja Permaisuri Bainun, Ipoh. The inscription reads: “Presented by Low Foo Esq to the Ipoh Hospital. Maker: Penang Foundry.” Photograph by Edwin Seibel Nathan, used with permission.

In addition, a road in Ipoh, Jalan Low Foo, was named in his honour, providing further evidence of his recognised standing in the local community.

²⁰ Khoo Salma Nasution, *Streets of George Town, Penang* (Penang: Areca Books, 2007).

²¹ UNESCO, World Heritage Centre, *Melaka and George Town, Historic Cities of the Straits of Malacca: Nomination Dossier* (2008).

Field observation conducted by the author in Ipoh in April 2026 confirms the continued existence of Jalan Low Foo. A surviving street sign bearing the name, though weathered and partially faded, remains visible at the site, providing physical evidence of the road’s continued recognition. The surrounding streetscape reflects a residential area consistent with early twentieth-century urban development in Ipoh.

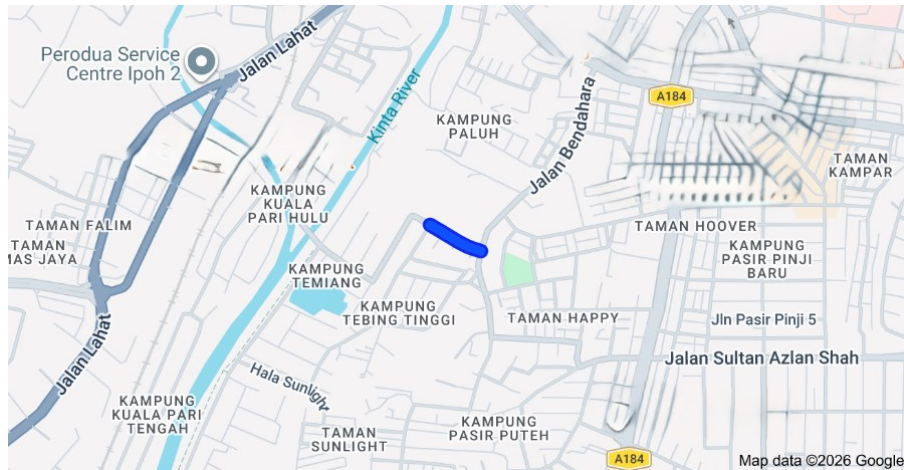


Figure 10. Location of Jalan Low Foo, Ipoh, Perak, highlighted in blue. The lane is situated within the Kampung Tebing Tinggi area, in proximity to the Kinta River and Jalan Sultan Azlan Shah (A184). Map adapted from Google Maps.



Figure 11. Jalan Low Foo street sign, Ipoh. The sign, though weathered and partially faded, clearly preserves the name “Jalan Low Foo”, providing physical evidence of the road named in honour of Low Foo. Photograph by the author.



Figure 12. The present streetscape surrounding Jalan Low Foo provides visual context for the road’s continued location within a long-established residential area of Ipoh. Photograph by the author.

A contemporaneous shipping notice published in *The Straits Independent and Penang Chronicle* on 26 March 1890 records a “Mr. Low Foo” arriving from Taiping via the s.s. *Thaiping*.²² Although brief, the notice places Low Foo within the Taiping–Penang corridor during the height of the Larut mining era and provides additional documentary evidence linking him to the commercial and mining networks of Perak in the late nineteenth century. The reference also suggests a degree of mobility and standing consistent with individuals engaged in regional enterprise and commercial activity during this period.

²²*The Straits Independent and Penang Chronicle* (Penang), 26 March 1890, p. 5, “List of Passengers.”

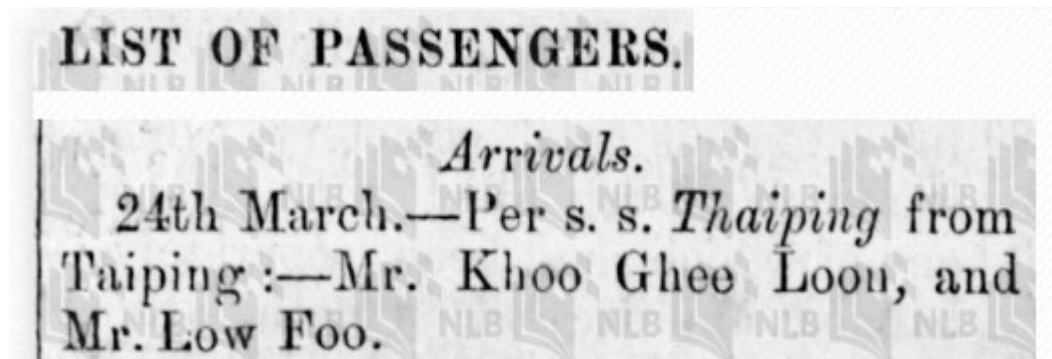


Figure 13. Passenger notice published in *The Straits Independent and Penang Chronicle* on 26 March 1890 recording ‘Mr. Low Foo’ arriving from Taiping via the s.s. *Thaiping*. The notice provides contemporaneous documentary evidence placing Low Foo within the Penang–Taiping corridor during the late nineteenth century.

Further evidence of Low Foo’s mining activities appears in a notice published in the *Perak Government Gazette* dated 6 September 1907. Issued under Section 31(1) of the Mining Enactment, 1904, the notice lists “Low Foo and Chung Ki Siew” as holders of a mining lease in Teja, Kinta. The notice stated that the lease had become liable to forfeiture due to an alleged failure to fulfil the required labour conditions attached to the concession.

NOTIFICATION UNDER SECTION 21 (i) OF “THE MINING ENACTMENT, 1904.”
NOTICE TO SHOW CAUSE WHY LEASES SHOULD NOT BE FORFEITED.

No. 714.—Whereas there is reason to believe that the persons enumerated in the schedule hereto have severally failed to fulfil the labour conditions of the leases herein shown as held by each of them, respectively, in consequence whereof the said leases have become liable to forfeiture; now, with the approval of the Resident, I call upon each of the said persons, within three months from the service on them of this notice, to show cause to the satisfaction of the Resident why the said leases should not be forfeited.

Dated this 16th day of August, 1907.

SCHEDULE.

Under what Code or Enactment Issued.	Lessee.	Mukim.	Title.	Date of Title.	Plan No.	Area.	Boundaries.
			M. L.			A. R. P.	
“Mining Enactment, 1899”	Kok Kim Eok	Teja ...	4,770	1/11,89	8,936	7 1 33	N., State Land and Plan No. 6,547; E., State Land; S., Plan No. 8,950; W., Plan Nos. 1,554, 6,338 and 749.
“Mining Code, 1895.”	Low Foo and Chung Ki Siew	“ ...	2,859	3/ 2 98	6,547	9 3 14	N., State Land and Lot No. 612; E., Road; S., State Land; W., State Land.

A. F. WORTHINGTON,
Collector.

Figure 14. Notice published in the *Perak Government Gazette* dated 6 September 1907 listing ‘Low Foo and Chung Ki Siew’ as holders of a mining lease in Teja, Kinta, issued under section 31(1) of the Mining Enactment, 1904. The notice provides official colonial documentary evidence linking Low Foo to mining operations in the Kinta district during the early twentieth century.

Additional archival records held by Arkib Negara Malaysia further suggest that an individual identified as “Low Foo” remained involved in mining and prospecting ventures beyond Perak during the early twentieth century. Records dated 2 December 1910 refer to applications by “Low Foo” for mining rights over land at Rasa, Selangor, including one jointly submitted with Mahmood bin Kassim. A further archival record dated 10 January 1913 refers to a “Prospecting Licence Application – 500 Acres, Peretak Mukim, Towkay Low Foo.” These records likely refer to the same Low Foo associated with mining activities discussed in this

study, the combination of name, period and mining context suggests a possible connection warranting further research.²³

His association with mining operations in Perak is also reflected in a report published in *The Straits Times* on 24 January 1917, which stated that “Towkay Low Foo” had brought a legal claim against the Government of Perak seeking damages arising from the alleged wrongful opening of a dam in the vicinity of his mine.²⁴ This reference independently confirms Low Foo’s active association with mining operations in Perak during the early twentieth century and is consistent with broader family accounts linking the family to the mining industry.

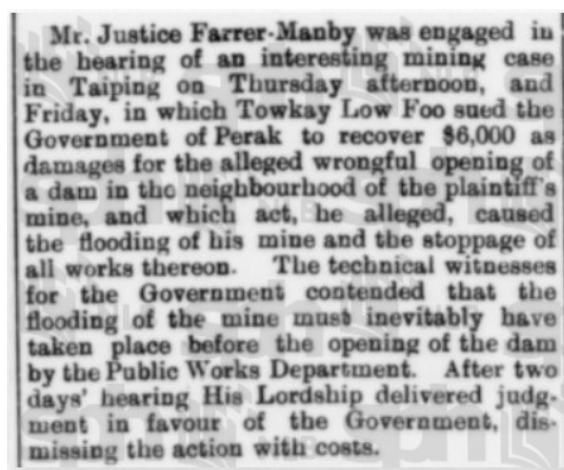


Figure 15. A report published in *The Straits Times* on 24 January 1917, which stated that ‘Towkay Low Foo’ had brought a legal claim against the Government of Perak seeking damages arising from the alleged wrongful opening of a dam in the vicinity of his mine.

Later Life and Estimated Chronology of Low Foo

The available documentary record allows for only a partial reconstruction of Low Foo’s life chronology.

Court records indicate that by 19 October 1927, Low Foo is described as deceased, with Lin Pui Yew recorded as acting “as surviving executrix and representative of the estate of Low Foo deceased”²⁵ in a land charge transaction.

Further court records, including *Lau Yau Weng and Lau Yau Chi v Bank of Malaya Ltd* [1933] 1 MLJ 250, corroborate his prior death, with land forming part of his estate transferred on 24 February 1930 to Lau Yau Weng and Lau Yau Chi.²⁶

²³Arkib Negara Malaysia (ANM), records relating to mining and prospecting applications by “Low Foo” and “Towkay Low Foo” in Selangor, including Identifier Nos. 1957/0154844W, 1957/0154845W and 1957/0167270W, Pejabat Setiausaha Kerajaan Negeri Selangor, dated 2 December 1910 and 10 January 1913.

²⁴*The Straits Times* (Singapore) on 24 January 1917, p. 8.

²⁵*Lau Yau Weng and Lau Yau Chi v Bank of Malaya Ltd* [1933] 1 MLJ 250 (High Court, Ipoh, 20 April 1933), where Lin Pui Yew is described as “the surviving executrix and representative of the estate of Low Foo, deceased.”

²⁶*Lau Yau Weng and Lau Yau Chi v Bank of Malaya Ltd* [1933] 1 MLJ 250; see also *Lau Yau Weng and Lau Yau Chi v Bank of Malaya Ltd* [1933–34] FMSLR 28.

The exact relationship between Lin Pui Yew and Low Foo is not stated in the available records, though her role as executrix indicates that she held a recognised and authorised position in the administration of his estate.

Although family recollections describe Low Foo as having died relatively young, possibly at around forty years of age, the broader family chronology suggests he may have been older than later memory implied, perhaps in his fifties or sixties at the time of death.

Family accounts also indicate that Low Foo suffered from a large tumour in the neck. During a visit to Ipoh, he is reported in family accounts to have collapsed at a garden gathering, after which he was sent to Hong Kong for medical treatment. He later died there.

Following his death, the properties at Nos. 381–383 Chulia Street passed to his sons. The mansion remained one of the most significant family properties inherited by the next generation and would later play an important role in the family’s wartime experiences.

Family Burial Cluster and Additional Members of Low Foo’s Household

Field observation and correlation with family records have identified a cluster of graves associated with members of Low Foo’s immediate family. These burials provide rare physical evidence that complements the oral and documentary record, providing additional insight into family relationships.

Additional evidence relating to the immediate family structure of Lau Yau Weng suggests the presence of elder siblings not previously identified in the documented lineage. Family oral accounts consistently recall that Lau Yau Weng had two elder sisters.²⁷ One individual who may correspond to one of these sisters is Low Lai Cheng, whose grave records her birth on 21 May 1892 and her death on 12 February 1950.

The identification is supported by several converging observations. Her use of the Romanised surname “Low” reflects the earlier spelling employed prior to the transition to “Lau”, which was introduced by Lau Yau Weng himself following his English education. This suggests that she belonged to the same generation but did not adopt the revised spelling. In addition, her burial within the same family grave cluster, immediately adjacent to that of Lau Yau Tuck, a known member of the same sibling generation, provides further support for this association. This spatial arrangement was documented during field investigation.

Taken together, these elements indicate that Low Lai Cheng was most likely one of the elder sisters of Lau Yau Weng and, by extension, a daughter of Low Foo, based on combined oral testimony, burial evidence and family records.

The Chinese inscription does not record her personal name, identifying her instead by her surname 劉 (Liú) and the honorific 安人, in accordance with traditional practice. Her name ‘Low Lai Cheng’ is preserved in the English inscription.

²⁷ Oral testimony preserved within the Lau family and collected by the author in April 2026.



Figure 16. Graves of Low Lai Cheng and Lau Yau Tuck, shown adjacent to each other within the Lau family burial cluster. Photograph by the author.



Figure 17. Grave of Low Lai Cheng. The Chinese inscription identifies her by surname 劉 and the honorific 安人, while her personal name appears in the English inscription. Photograph by the author.

Family accounts also record another son of Low Foo, Lau Yau Tuck, a brother of Lau Yau Weng, who was remembered among surviving family accounts to have died in or around 1927, reportedly from malaria. His grave, identified through field investigation and correlation with family records, is located within a Lau family burial cluster associated with earlier generations of the family.

This identification provides rare physical corroboration of a figure previously preserved only in family memory.

3. Lau Yau Weng (劉有榮/刘有荣 Liú Yǒuróng) and Lau Yau Chi (劉有_ /刘有_ Liú Yǒu_)

Transition of the family from Penang to Ipoh

Following the death of Low Foo, his estate passed to his sons, Lau Yau Weng, the eldest, and Lau Yau Chi (劉有_ / 刘有_ Liú Yǒu_, final character unverified), the fourth son. The shared middle name “Yau” reflects the use of a traditional Chinese generation name within the family. Beyond references appearing in legal and family records, little additional information regarding Lau Yau Chi survives in present family memory and his descendants fall outside the single documented line reconstructed in this study.

During this period, the family’s centre of residence shifted from Penang to Ipoh, marking a transition from the earlier Penang-based household to a more established presence in Perak. Surviving birth records of the next generation provide further documentary evidence for this transition.

Lau Yau Weng was married to Wong Suk Ching, a Burmese Chinese. He later resided in Ipoh with his wife and their family, where the household remained for many years. Wong Suk Ching passed away in 1972. An obituary notice published at the time recorded her age as seventy-two, placing her birth circa 1900.



Figure 18. Portraits of Wong Suk Ching (left) and Lau Yau Weng (right). Photograph courtesy of the family.

In his later years, Lau Yau Weng lived with his youngest son, Lau Kok Leong (刘国量 Liú Guóliàng), at Jalan Potter in Taman Canning, Ipoh. An obituary notice published upon his death in 1975 recorded his age as eighty-one, placing his birth circa 1894. According to family accounts preserved by Yip Yuen Thoo, wife of Lau Yook Loon, he died from pneumonia and was cremated.

4. Children of Lau Yau Weng

Lau Yau Weng and Wong Suk Ching had the following children:

- Lau Hoi Leong (刘海量 Liú Hǎiliàng) – eldest son, born 1919. His surviving birth certificate records his birth at 381 Chulia Street, Penang, linking the family directly to the Chulia Street residence associated with the wider Low Foo household during the early twentieth century.
- Lau Sum Yee (刘心仪 Liú Xīnyí) – adopted daughter
- Lau Foong Yee (刘凤仪 Liú Fèngyí) – daughter, born 1928
- Lau Sun Leong (刘申量 Liú Shēnliàng) – son
- Lau Hor Leong (刘河量 Liú Héliàng) – son, born 1931
- Lau Kok Leong (刘国量 Liú Guóliàng) – son
- Lau Mei Yee (刘美仪 Liú Měiyí) – daughter, born 1934

The sons share the common generational character 量 (liàng), while the daughters' names consistently include the character 仪 (yí).

A surviving birth certificate of Lau Foong Yee, registered on 31 August 1928, records her birth on 26 August 1928 at 24 Belfield Street, Ipoh, identifying both parents, Lau Yau Weng and Wong Suk Ching, as “Kek”, a colonial-era term commonly used in Malaya to refer to the Hakka (客家 Kèjiā) Chinese dialect group. The same document lists Lau Yau Weng's occupation as “Towkay Lombong”, a Malay term meaning mine owner. The record also provides contemporaneous documentary evidence linking the family to the Belfield Street residence later associated with the family's wartime experiences during the Japanese occupation. Taken together, these details suggest that the Lau family belonged to the Hakka community and retained connections to the mining industry in Perak during that period.

Based on surviving documentary evidence, the relocation of Lau Yau Weng and his immediate family from Penang to Ipoh most likely occurred sometime between the death of Low Foo, who was already recorded as deceased by 19 October 1927, and the birth of Lau

Foong Yee at Belfield Street, Ipoh on 26 August 1928. As Lau Hoi Leong's 1919 birth certificate still records the family at 381 Chulia Street, Penang, the available evidence suggests that the transition of the family's principal residence from Penang to Ipoh probably took place during this period following Low Foo's death.

5. Later generations

The family lineage continued through the descendants of Lau Yau Weng.

One of the later descendants was Lau Hoi Leong, who served as Assistant Headmaster at Yuk Kwan School in Batu Gajah, located in the Kinta Valley tin-mining region.

His eldest son was Lau Yook Loon, born in 1944, through whom the family line continues.

Family tradition also preserves the inheritance of a statue of the deity Guan Yin (观音 Guān Yīn), believed to have been passed down through several generations of the family. According to family accounts, the statue originally belonged to Wong Suk Ching, wife of Lau Yau Weng, who had brought it from her ancestral family background connected to Burma before it later passed through the maternal line within the Lau family. The preservation of the statue across successive generations reflects both continuity of family memory and the transmission of religious and cultural traditions within the household. The statue is currently in the possession of Ang Lay Cheng (洪丽真 Hóng Lìzhēn), daughter of Lau Mei Yee, where it continues to be preserved as a family heirloom.



Figure 19. Statue of Guan Yin (观音 Guān Yīn), preserved within the Lau family and currently held by Ang Lay Cheng. Photograph courtesy of the family.

6. A Wartime Episode During the Japanese Occupation

Later accounts preserved by descendants of the Lau family indicate that by the time of the Japanese invasion of Malaya in December 1941, the family was no longer living in Penang.

Following the death of Low Foo, who is documented as deceased by 1927, members of the family relocated from Penang to Ipoh in Perak. Lau Yau Weng moved there together with his wife Wong Suk Ching and his mother, the widow of Low Foo, referred to within the family as 'Tai Thai', the matriarch of the household. Several other members of the extended family are also believed to have relocated to Ipoh during this period.

Upon settling in Ipoh, the family established their home at No. 24 Belfield Street²⁸ (now Jalan Sultan Yusoff), a property owned by Lau Yau Weng following the family's move from Penang. As with many such properties, domestic life and commercial activity were closely intertwined. This arrangement was characteristic of urban commercial properties in early Malaya, reflecting a practical integration of enterprise and household life.

One of the family's businesses operating from this address was Winson Company Limited. The business dealt in imported, high-quality radio equipment, public address systems and communication devices, including internationally recognised brands of the time. Its product range suggests that it operated within the upper tier of commercial trade, serving a market for advanced and relatively specialised technological goods.

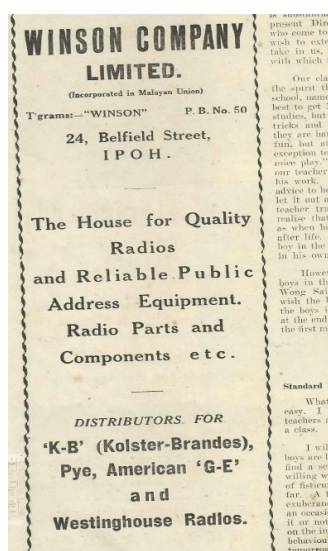


Figure 20. Advertisement for Winson Company Limited, No. 24 Belfield Street, Ipoh. The company is presented as a distributor of internationally recognised brands such as 'K-B' (Kolster-Brandes), Pye, General Electric (G.E.), and Westinghouse. These were premium radio and communications manufacturers of their time, indicating that Winson Company dealt in imported, high-quality equipment positioned within the upper segment of the market.

²⁸Affidavit of assets filed in the estate of Lau Yau Weng (c.1975), confirming his ownership of No. 24 Belfield Street, Ipoh, among other properties.

A site visit conducted in April 2026 to Jalan Sultan Yusoff (formerly Belfield Street) further confirms that the surviving row of shophouses retains the characteristic narrow frontage and extended depth typical of early twentieth-century commercial properties. The spatial arrangement supports the interpretation that the premises functioned as both a business and residence, consistent with family accounts describing commercial activity on the ground floor with living quarters above.

Field Identification of No. 24 Belfield Street (present-day Jalan Sultan Yusoff)

Field verification confirms that the present-day property occupied by ARF Bistro corresponds to No. 24 Belfield Street, the former residence and business premises associated with Lau Yau Weng.

The Perak Hainan Association, located at Nos. 28 and 30 Jalan Sultan Yusoff and established in 1912, provides a fixed historical reference point. Information provided by the Association indicates that although the street name changed from Belfield Street to Jalan Sultan Yusoff, the shop lot numbering has remained unchanged since its establishment.

Based on this preserved numbering system and the immediate adjacency of the ARF Bistro unit to the Association building, the property can be identified as No. 24 within the original sequence. This identification is further supported by long-term local testimony, including that of a nearby business owner with over four decades of continuous operation, who independently confirmed that the street name changed while numbering remained intact.

These elements — fixed institutional reference, preserved numbering system and spatial continuity — establish the present-day site of ARF Bistro as the historical location of No. 24 Belfield Street.

The building forms part of a continuous row of pre-war shophouses along Jalan Sultan Yusoff (formerly Belfield Street), reflecting early twentieth-century urban development patterns in Ipoh. The consistency of the streetscape suggests that the present configuration closely corresponds to its historical arrangement.



Figure 21. Streetscape showing No. 24 Jalan Sultan Yusoff (formerly Belfield Street), Ipoh. The preserved numbering sequence and adjacency to the Perak Hainan Association (Nos. 28 and 30), established in 1912, support identification of the present-day premises as former No. 24 Belfield Street. Photograph by the author.



Figure 22. Closer view of No. 24 Jalan Sultan Yusoff and adjacent to the Perak Hainan Association building. The spatial relationship between the present-day premises and the adjacent Association building further corroborates continuity of the original street numbering sequence associated with former No. 24 Belfield Street. Photograph by the author.

This account is further supported by oral testimony preserved across multiple generations of the family. Lau Foong Yee, daughter of Lau Yau Weng, had lived at the Belfield Street residence during her youth. Ang Lay Cheng, granddaughter of Lau Yau Weng, also visited and stayed at the property as a child. These independent recollections, drawn from direct lived experience, reinforce the identification of the premises as the family's residence at No. 24 Belfield Street.

When Japanese forces occupied Malaya during the war years (1941–1945), the Belfield Street residence was reported in family accounts to have been plundered, resulting in the loss of many of the family's possessions.

During this turbulent period, the family temporarily fled to Tanjung Rambutan, seeking safety away from the town. The property in Tanjung Rambutan where they stayed did not belong to the family but served as a temporary refuge during the occupation.

According to accounts preserved by later descendants, when the family later returned to their Belfield Street home, they discovered that the house had been ransacked and that most of the family's money and possessions had been lost. The shock and distress of this discovery, as reported in family accounts, affected the family matriarch, 'Tai Thai', a Hokkien woman, deeply. She later fell ill and passed away in Ipoh. Accounts preserved by Yip Yuen Thoo, wife of Lau Yook Loon, further indicated that she died in 1948 and was buried in Tambun, Ipoh, an event remembered within the family as being closely associated with the grief caused by the wartime losses.

Family testimony also recalls that during the Japanese occupation, Lau Yau Weng was arrested by the Japanese authorities and is remembered in family accounts as having been subjected to torture. During this period many prominent Chinese residents in Malaya were detained by the Japanese authorities, who suspected the community of supporting resistance efforts. To secure his release, a ransom was demanded. To raise the required money, his wife

Wong Suk Ching arranged for the sale of the family's property at Nos. 381–383 Chulia Street in Penang. The building had been the former residence of Low Foo and remained under the ownership of the Lau family even after they had relocated to Ipoh. The property was reported in later family accounts to have been sold to a Chettiar moneylender operating along Chulia Street at that time. No deed of sale has yet been located.

These accounts handed down through later generations reflect the severe disruption and hardship experienced by many Chinese families in Malaya during the Japanese occupation and mark a turning point in the fortunes of the Lau family.²⁹

7. The transition from “Low” to “Lau”

Both spellings refer to the same Chinese surname: 劉/刘 (Liú). The traditional form 劉 reflects the historical usage during the nineteenth-century, while the simplified form 刘 is widely used in modern writing. In this study, both forms are presented to aid clarity for contemporary readers while preserving historical accuracy.

Within this family, the variation in Romanised surname forms reflects the broader historical practice of non-standardised transcription in colonial records. Against this background, the surname 劉/刘 appears in different forms in English sources, including Low, Lau, Lew, Loo and Liu. These variations do not indicate different identities but arise from phonetic rendering across dialects.

Among the earlier generations, including Low Sam and Low Foo, the spelling “Low” was used in English records of the period.

The transition to “Lau” is understood to have occurred during the time of Lau Yau Weng, who had received an English education. According to family accounts, he felt that the spelling “Low” did not adequately reflect the Cantonese pronunciation of the surname and might lead to mispronunciation by English speakers. He therefore adopted the spelling “Lau”, which more closely approximates the Cantonese sound. From his generation onward, the family consistently used the spelling “Lau”, which has remained in use to the present day.

²⁹ Paul H. Kratoska, *The Japanese Occupation of Malaya* (Honolulu: University of Hawai'i Press, 1998); Christopher Bayly and Tim Harper, *Forgotten Armies* (London: Allen Lane, 2004).

Acknowledgements

Much of the family history recorded in this article has been preserved through oral accounts shared by later descendants of the Lau family. Unless otherwise noted, oral accounts were collected directly by the author between 2018 and 2026 from living descendants. The preparation of this record benefited from the recollections and contributions of the following individuals:

- Lau Foong Yee (刘凤仪 Liú Fèngyí) – daughter of Lau Yau Weng
- Yip Yuen Thoo (叶润桃 Yè Rùntáo) – wife of Lau Yook Loon
- Chin Siew Kuen (陈秀娟 Chén Xiùjuān) – daughter of Lau Foong Yee
- Lau Tuck Yoong (刘德容 Liú Déyóng) – daughter of Lau Yook Loon
- Ang Lay Heok (洪丽叶 Hóng Lìyè) – daughter of Lau Mei Yee
- Ang Lay Cheng (洪丽真 Hóng Lìzhēn) – daughter of Lau Mei Yee
- Ang Lay Guan (洪利源 Hóng Lìyuán) – son of Lau Mei Yee
- Chin Toong Onn Bernard (陈东安 Chén Dōng'ān) – son of Lau Foong Yee
- Dora Chin-Tan Ai Yuen (陈爱运 Chén Àiyùn) – daughter-in-law of Lau Foong Yee
- Lau Yoke Ping, Angela (刘玉冰 Liú Yùbīng) – daughter of Lau Hor Leong
- Loke Gim Tay – current owner of the former residence of Low Foo at Nos. 381–383 Chulia Street, Penang, for providing information on the building's architecture, construction materials and historical layout

The author is connected to the Lau family through marriage and undertook this study in part to preserve and document his wife's maternal family history for future generations.

Their accounts helped preserve family memories relating to Low Foo, Lau Yau Weng, and the experiences of the family during the Japanese occupation, allowing these events to be recorded for future generations.

Researched, Compiled and Written by

Ho Siew Khui (何小駒 Hé Xiǎojū)

Correspondence:

Ho Siew Khui

Email: laufamilylineage@gmail.com

This historical account draws on historical research and oral testimony preserved by members of the Lau family. The author expresses his gratitude to the family members whose recollections helped preserve the memories recorded in this document.

This study reflects the information presently available and may be updated if additional historical documents or family recollections emerge.

Sources and Methodology

This historical account is based on a combination of oral history, field-based observation and documentary research, including published historical works, archival records, contemporaneous newspaper reports and relevant court documents. Information was gathered from family members, whose recollections have been carefully considered and corroborated where possible.

The author conducted informal interviews between 2018 and 2026 with living descendants of the Lau family. Where accounts differed, details were compared across sources and considered alongside available documentary evidence and site observations, with preference given to points of consistency.

The author conducted site visits between March 2018 and April 2026 to key locations including Chulia Street (Penang) and Jalan Sultan Yusoff (Ipoh), allowing direct observation of architectural features and spatial layouts relevant to the family's residential and commercial history. These observations, supported by photographic documentation, also provided context for assessing oral accounts where relevant.

Additional documentary research included systematic searches of historical newspaper archives and published records from Singapore and Malaya, including reports preserved in publications such as the *Pinang Gazette and Straits Chronicle*, *The Straits Times* and *The Straits Independent and Penang Chronicle*, together with historical legal records relating to land, probate and commercial matters. Contemporary reports of Supreme Court proceedings were examined alongside other documentary evidence where they identified family relationships or property interests relevant to this study. These materials were used to corroborate oral testimony, establish chronology and identify contemporaneous references connected to members of the Lau family lineage.

Research for this study also included consultation of archival catalogues and administrative records held by Arkib Negara Malaysia (ANM), including materials accessible through the Online Finding Aid (OFA) system and the Colonial Office collections available via Gale Primary Sources. These records provided additional contemporaneous references relating to mining activities, land matters and associated individuals connected to the Low family lineage and the wider historical context of Perak and British Malaya.

The broader historical context regarding the Japanese occupation of Malaya and Penang (1941–1945), including the treatment of Chinese communities and the economic disruptions of the period, is supported by established historical studies such as Paul H. Kratoska's *The Japanese Occupation of Malaya: A Social and Economic History* (1998) and Christopher Bayly and Tim Harper's *Forgotten Armies: Britain's Asian Empire and the War with Japan* (2004).

Additional contextual information on Penang's commercial society and historical properties is informed by works such as those of Khoo Salma Nasution, particularly her studies on Penang's heritage and merchant communities. Background on the role of Chettiar financiers in Malaya is also drawn from historical literature on South Indian merchant networks in Southeast Asia.

The account of the early development of the Larut tin mining industry, including figures such as Kapitan Chung Keng Quee and Low Sam of Penang, draws on established historical scholarship, archival records and published studies. These include works by C.N. Parkinson, Khoo Kay Kim, Barbara Watson Andaya and Leonard Y. Andaya, as well as Yen Ching-hwang, alongside corroborative online and archival sources consulted in the preparation of this study.

As with many nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Chinese family histories in Malaya, parts of the lineage remain fragmentary due to the incomplete survival of personal and administrative records.

Archival Limitations

As part of efforts to obtain primary documentary evidence to establish familial relationships within the Lau lineage, the author submitted two formal applications to the Penang High Court on 16 April 2026 to search for probate-related records. These included requests for certified true copies of wills, grants of probate, letters of administration and related estate files associated with Low Sam (circa 1870–1900) and Low Foo (circa 1927).

Following an internal review by court personnel, the author was informed that records exceeding 100 years in age are not retained. The applications were therefore returned without action. As a result, no probate or estate files for Low Sam or Low Foo were available through the Penang High Court for the relevant periods. Nevertheless, subsequent research identified contemporaneous Supreme Court proceedings reported in the *Pinang Gazette and Straits Chronicle* (26 February 1897), which independently confirmed Low Foo's role as administrator of the estate of his father, Low Ah Sam.

These applications were undertaken in part to seek documentary confirmation of the filial relationships between Low Sam and Low Foo and between Low Foo and Lau Yau Weng, as well as to identify potential evidence regarding family structure, including spouses, descendants and property holdings. Although the requested probate records could not be located, subsequent examination of contemporaneous newspaper reports provided independent documentary confirmation of the relationship between Low Sam and Low Foo. The absence of the probate records nevertheless reflects the broader archival limitations affecting many nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Chinese family histories in Malaya.

In addition to documentary research, an attempt was made to examine cemetery burial records maintained by the Kwangtung-Tengchow Association, Penang, which administers burial records for Mount Erskine Cemetery. While burials at the site date back to the late eighteenth century, the surviving written records held by the Association survive only from 1927 onwards. The author conducted a search on 16 April 2026 with the objective of identifying burial records associated with the Lau family, with particular focus on Lau Yau Tuck, whose burial location was regarded as a potential point of reference for locating the wider Lau family burial cluster.

The available records were found to be in a severely deteriorated condition, with many pages damaged and no longer accessible for systematic review. It was further indicated by the Association that a substantial portion of earlier records had been lost during the Second World War and that the surviving volumes represent only a partial archival record. As a result, no relevant burial entries were identified through the Association's records.

In parallel with this archival search, the author undertook field investigation at Mount Erskine Cemetery between 16 and 18 April 2026. The search strategy focused on locating the grave of Lau Yau Tuck, based on family accounts identifying him as a member of the Lau family burial group associated with the earlier generation of Low Sam. Several graves associated with members of the Lau family were identified through physical survey and correlation with family records. However, while a grave attributed to Lau Yau Tuck was identified, the broader burial context could not be conclusively established as a single formally defined or intact family tomb compound. In addition, the graves attributed to earlier generations, including Low Sam, could not be definitively located.

Observations at the site indicate that portions of the cemetery have been altered by subsequent development, including land clearance and the construction of access roads, which may have affected the preservation, integrity or visibility of earlier burial sites.

Further research may be undertaken through alternative archival sources, including overseas repositories, clan association records or private estate papers, should such materials become available.

Dates and family relationships presented in this study are reconstructed from the best available documentary, legal and oral evidence. Where relationships are explicitly stated in contemporaneous primary sources, they are presented as documented. In other instances, relationships remain historical reconstructions based on the convergence of multiple independent sources.

Author

Ho Siew Khui 何小駒 (Hé Xiǎojū)

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This work is a self-published family historical study based on family records, oral history, field observation and documentary research.

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